school was next to the railway station, so whenever we got a break, we would go and help my father,' Prahlad told me. Later, as a teenager, Modi worked with his uncle Babubhai who had a canteen-cum-tea shop near Ahmedabad's bus station. 'Narendrabhai would get up at 4.30 a.m., make hot pakoras and chai and sell them at the bus stand,' claims Prahlad. Congress leader Ahmed Patel says Modi would only sit at the billing counter of his uncle's canteen. 'From what I have found out, he never actually sold tea,' Patel claims. It seemed to me a case of nitpicking. Modi had, all said and done, endured a tough childhood.

Maybe some of the hardships had been dramatized over the years. Ambedkar decried India's hero-worshipping culture and indeed we Indians quickly make legends of our leaders. Many apocryphal stories are spun and admiringly retold about a larger-than-life figure. In Vadnagar, I was told that Modi as a child had swum across the lake braving crocodiles!

Fact or fiction, the chaiwallah story had acquired a life of its own. As always with Modi's campaign, the choreography and use of technology was brilliant. The first Chai pe Charcha event took place on 12 February 2014 from the Iskcon tea stall in Ahmedabad. It was relayed live in 1000 tea stalls in 300 cities, all connected by video conference. Modi would appear on a giant screen at each stall with a cup of a tea in hand, taking selected questions from the CAG website. 'We created a truly multi-media event that played out on television, Internet, mobile and DTH,' says Kishore.

The theme for the first 'charcha' was Modi's favourite subject—good governance. In March, on International Women's Day, Modi's second discussion over 'chai' was on women's safety and empowerment. Modi sat in a tea stall in Delhi, a city which in the aftermath of the anti-rape protests was a perfect location for the subject. The third and final charcha was at the end of March, from Vidarbha in Maharashtra, where the conversation was on farmmer's suicides in a region where agrarian distress was a major concern. 'The locations, the topics, all were chosen with an eye on what makes news,' says a Team Modi member. Using satellite technology, the three Chai pe Charcha events touched 500 cities and 4000 locations—the messaging had been scaled up in typical Modi style. Interestingly, one of